

ART

Local Sculpture Shown On Hospital's Grounds

By HELEN A. HARRISON

NOW in its seventh season, the annual outdoor sculpture exhibition at Mather Memorial Hospital in Port Jefferson occupies both the rolling front lawn and the enclosed courtyard of the building complex. Works by 10 Long Island artists are on view through Friday.

Visitors' initial encounters are with aluminum pieces by David T. Haussler, who lives in Oakdale; Bill Kiriazis, an East Hampton sculptor, and James Kleege of Port Jefferson Station, as well as Philippe Maucotel's multi-part "S Matrix Frolicking," which punctuates the green-sward.

Mr. Maucotel, whose studio is in Cutchogue, has used the letter S as a symbol of plurality. Rendered in concrete, the letter is sited at various spots around the lawn, turning the grass into grasses, a tree into trees and a bush into bushes, simply by its proximity to those elements of the landscape.

The sculptural aspects of the installation are, in fact, secondary to its conceptual qualities. That is to say that the letter is, in itself, unremarkable as an object, but its symbolic implications are intriguing.

When paired, the forms suggest courtship and mating, with slight differences of color and texture signifying the compatibility of variations on a basic theme. In one pairing, the couple has produced an offspring — a chip off the old block, so to speak — which echoes its parentage.

Mr. Kleege's "Tension" is a balletic interplay of parabolic curves held in balance by steel cables. Its four aluminum I-beams seem to float weightlessly in space, yet the entire structure is solidly anchored by a mathematically precise system of dynamics.

This arrangement recalls the pipe and cable constructions of Kenneth Snelson, to whom Mr. Kleege is obviously indebted. However, while Mr. Snelson's forms rely on angular progressions, Mr. Kleege has varied the formula with sweeping arcs of twisted metal to counteract the stiffness of the connecting wires.

Mr. Kiriazis plays off curve against plane in "Evening Harmony," an elegant arrangement of aluminum strips arching over a long, hollow rectangle that channels its energy downward toward the earth. In minimal, abstract terms, the piece suggests the sun's steady decline through its descending phases.

"Saturn One," another aluminum construction, is Mr. Haussler's more overt allusion to planetary movement, although it, too, is far from literally descriptive. Saturn's gaseous atmosphere is evoked by means of a roughly textured surface that also gives the impression of volume to a flat sheet of metal, while the translucency of the planet's rings is implied by the same method.

Rather than simply presenting the celestial body as a floating form in space, the artist has shown it partly hidden by the earth, as if emerging from obscurity. Indeed, as space probes reveal more about the nature of the universe, Saturn and the other components of our solar system are becoming increasingly visible, as this sculpture suggests.

Sheet aluminum is also the chosen material of Diane Wiczorek of Huntington, whose "Aimed Forces" is installed in the hospital's courtyard. Her arrangement of complementary energies benefits, as does Mr. Haussler's piece, from the light-reflecting character of brushed sur-



"Saturn One," a work in aluminum by David T. Haussler

face make a winning pair, exploiting the contrast between flat and arching elements. "Rhythm and Three Blues," using a trio of blue squares to make its point, relies too heavily on the visual pun that gives the piece its title.

Ralph Claro, a Mastic artist, has produced objects that are more like graphic design than sculpture. "The Oak," a cutout leaf shape in Corten steel, could be the logo of a forestry service, but it has nothing to do with the creation of form in three dimensions.

Similarly, Mr. Claro's "Monarch," a gaily painted butterfly made of sheet metal, is no more than an effective decorative screen, while "Sky-light," is a flat, stylized lightning bolt, pure and simple.

Christopher Solbert, on the other hand, has tried to animate lifeless steel beams in "Oriental Fan," although the result is not entirely successful. Mr. Solbert, a resident of Lloyd Harbor, has arranged upright elements in subtle undulations that attractively mimic the graceful curves of a waving fan, but his addi-

tion of baroque fringes seems necessarily fussy.

Simplicity is the hallmark of ceramic pieces by John Selden. Their surface color tures add understated visual interest to the basic monolithic form.

Mr. Casper's objects have a rare, magical quality, like mans and sacred stones clearly inspired them. Although much in the modern idiom, they forge a compelling link with deeply rooted in the unconscious, and they succeed.

"Cloak and Dagger," a work by the Southampton artist James does not quite gel as an effective treatment of a menacing "Hand," an oversize fist carved in bone — the work of Gavin Glen Head — looks like a relic from some roadside colossus, tising, say, the Cave-Man that kitschy context, it works here, it just falls flat.

The hospital is on North Road, just east of Route 119. Sculptures can be seen daily from 10 A.M. to 8 P.M.

